Headache diary · 8 weeks

Name _____ Start date _____

How to use it

1. Fill in one row every day, including days without headache: write N. Pain-free days count too.
2. Note when a headache started and ended, and the worst pain from 0 (none) to 10 (worst imaginable).
3. Write every medicine you take for headache, prescribed or not, with the dose and time, and whether it helped.
4. After each 4 weeks, fill in the summary on page 6. Bring the diary to your appointment.

UK guidance (NICE CG150) suggests keeping a headache diary for at least 8 weeks: how often, how long and how bad; other symptoms; all medicines; possible triggers; and any link to your period.

Don't wait: call your emergency number

for a sudden, extremely painful headache, or a headache with weakness or numbness on one side, trouble speaking, loss of vision, confusion, a seizure, or a high temperature or stiff neck.

Key

Symptoms	N nausea or vomiting · L light bothers you · S sound bothers you · A aura
Kind of medicine	T triptan C combination painkiller, such as one with caffeine or codeine P simple painkiller: paracetamol/acetaminophen, aspirin, ibuprofen or another NSAID O other: opioid, ergot or anything else
Helped?	Y yes · S somewhat · N no
Period	tick days you have your period

Why count medicine days?

Taking acute medicine on many days a month can make headaches more frequent. The international classification (ICHD-3) counts 10 or more days a month for triptans, ergots, opioids or combination painkillers, or for any mix of acute medicines (simple painkillers included), and 15 or more for simple painkillers alone. These are not safe limits: talk to your doctor, and don't stop or change medicines on your own.

Weeks 1–2

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period ✓	Notes

Weeks 3–4

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period ✓	Notes

Weeks 5–6

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period ✓	Notes

Weeks 7–8

From _____

Date	Headache? Y / N	Started time	Ended time	Worst pain 0–10	Symptoms N L S A	Medicine taken name, dose, time	Kind T C P O	Helped? Y / S / N	Possible triggers	Period ✓	Notes

Summary for your doctor

	Headache days	Migraine days (if known)	Days with simple painkillers (P)	Days with triptans (T)	Days with combination or other (C, O)	Days with any acute medicine	Worst pain
Weeks 1–4							
Weeks 5–8							

Medicines I take to prevent headaches

Questions for my doctor